

Introduction to the Curriculum

Dr. Caitlin Gunn and Dr. Caty Taborda have created this trauma-informed, culturally responsive, gender neutral curriculum for people who have been impacted by domestic violence. The curriculum is developed through an understanding of feminist, queer, and critical race theories, and is appropriate for ages 16 and up, with particular benefits for those ages 16 through 21. It is applicable to people and groups of all genders – women, men, non-binary and gender-fluid people, and mixed gender groups. This serves to provide maximum flexibility while also neutralizing language otherwise condemning and reducing individuals to identities of “abuser” and “victim.” Instead, lessons and group sessions refocus violent and toxic masculinities as the central cultural forces to be interrogated, understood, and challenged.

Trauma-informed

Trauma-informed curricula are designed to realize, recognize, and respond to the signs and impacts of trauma, and to avoid re-traumatization through emphasizing safety, transparency, empowerment, trust, and support.

We believe that no healing is possible without the involvement and agency of group participants, and without their trust and collaboration in the process. Our lesson plans are often open-ended and participant discussion-driven, and use a variety of different activities for individual and group reflection. These activities aid in the processing of trauma for people of different backgrounds and learning styles.

Culturally responsive

Many programs examine abuse without thinking about how abuse, violence, and toxic masculinity have different causes, solutions, and implications for different cultural backgrounds. Our curriculum works to reflect and explore the various religious, racial, and ethnic backgrounds that are being served in our communities, refusing to alienate people of color by whitewashing and making assumptions about the experiences of the people in the room. The Gunn Taborda curriculum rectifies these missteps through lessons addressing gender, culture, and race.

Gender neutral

Most often, domestic violence support groups are split into men's and women's groups with different curricula, different goals, and different messages. The oversimplification that happens when we treat our domestic violence groups as binary lessons for men and women is a problem that the Gunn Taborda Model seeks to address. We have been trained to think of abuser/abused dynamics as straightforward, black-and-white, from the abuser to the victim. Too often we hear "men's domestic violence group" and assume they are the perpetrators, and when we hear "women's group" we assume that these women have experienced abuse. While gender plays a large role in domestic violence, this separated configuration for support groups does not address those roles or their impact. It also risks oversimplifying the complex dynamics of domestic violence.

This gender neutral curriculum has two major goals:

1) Gender neutral programming speaks to people left out of binary dynamics of current support groups. For queer and/or gender non-conforming people, the models developed based on only discussion of men and women can erase their experiences entirely. With statistics indicating more and more young adults identify as queer in some capacity, our support needs to keep up with the needs of our communities. These support groups are often men's and women's groups for needs around safety and comfort, but it is not inconceivable that these notions of safety and comfort might change based on the participants. When the curriculum is gender neutral, we open up possibilities for other groupings, like young adult programming, for example.

2) Gender neutral programming ensures that everyone who participates in a support group using the Gunn Taborda Model has a universal and thorough understanding of the way abuse and power operate. Other models in widespread use, like the Duluth Model and The Power to Change, focus primarily on ensuring that women experiencing domestic violence never feel blamed or responsible for their abuse. Resisting victim-blaming is deeply important work, but lost in that framework is a holistic understanding of abuse and power in our culture. "Abusers" are the source of abuse and violence, and they are often also victims of abuse and trauma— sometimes within the same relationship. "Abusers" are the source of abuse

and violence, but there are multiple social forces at play worth understanding and interrogating. A curriculum that helps everyone understand concepts like toxic masculinity, patriarchy, gender roles, and regulating emotions and stress will give people a set of tools for recognizing and combating abusive patterns in their lives, wherever they show up.

Session format

Each session begins with the facilitator's choice of icebreaker activities (see Icebreaker List). Then, each lesson has a script, which may be adhered to exactly or in spirit, depending on the level of experience and training of the facilitator. The facilitator will share some initial thoughts and concepts to begin, and then the group will generally move into an activity or exercise. The majority of the lessons have an associated handout. All handouts are numbered and found at the end of this course pack. The handouts prompt individual reflection, provide information, or contain an activity based on the content of the lesson. The group always has a large group sharing component with a series of provided discussion questions. These questions relate and respond to both the lesson and unit concepts, and the session activity. This sharing component is the heart of the support group curriculum. Semi-structured discussions provide the space to concretize more abstract concepts and respond directly to participants and their individual needs. Facilitators should be flexible in their interpretation of the lessons in ways that best suit their particular group. Each lesson should conclude with a call for any questions about the material the group has covered. Other closing rituals, based on the size and engagement of the group, can include participants articulating one thing they've learned that day, their favorite or most useful component of the session, or how that day's session made them feel.